One further aspect of the CIA's conduct almost beggars belief: the agency conspired with members of the American Mafia to murder the Cuban Prime Minister. This was at the same time that the Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) was targeting the Mafia, including some of the very individuals involved in the assassination plotting. The CIA's endeavours began under the Eisenhower administration in 1960, when contact was established using a former FBI officer, Robert Maheu, as a 'cut-out'. Maheu was a friend of Johnny Roselli, who was closely connected to senior figures in the criminal underworld. Roselli introduced Maheu to Sam Giancana and Santo Trafficante. Howard Jones describes Giancana (a protégé of Al Capone) as a 'hotheaded and psychopathic yet charming and affable godfather' of the Chicago underworld.[59] Trafficante, who had been imprisoned by Castro for his criminal activities in Havana, was believed by the FBI to be responsible for at least thirteen murders in the United States. Presumably, he could be less charming and affable.

Giancana and Trafficante became key figures in CIA plotting, although in later years their professional relationship soured – Trafficante's butchered remains were found floating in an oil drum after Giancana's associates seem to have held him responsible for Giancana being shot dead at his home. Nevertheless, in 1960 Giancana and Trafficante were united in professing that they were motivated by patriotic duty and refused payment from the CIA for their attempts to procure Castro's murder.

The Mafia had strong motives for wanting Castro dead. Under Batista, the criminal underworld flourished in gambling, prostitution and the drugs trade in Havana. Castro eventually destroyed these enterprises, leaving Mafia leaders with a desire for vengeance. According to Santo Trafficante, the Mafia wrote off a hundred million dollars in the 'tourist' industry.[60]

When Richard Bissell met the CIA's Director of the Office of Security, Colonel Sheffield Edwards, in August 1960, they discussed the idea of using Cuban assassins in a 'gangster-type action.'[61] This was the sort of activity familiar to those acquainted with Mario Puzo's *The Godfather.* Trafficante and his colleagues, however, took a more clear-headed approach, inasmuch as they wanted to incentivise any would-be assassin with the possibility of escape. Accordingly, Trafficante requested poison